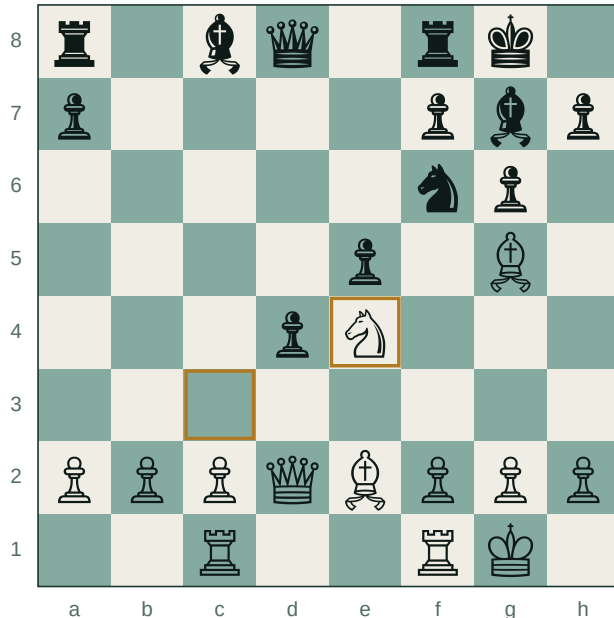


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 14

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 14.Ne4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

14...Nxe4 15. Bxd8 Nxd2

14...Nxe4 The knight captures the knight on e4. From e4 it attacks queen on d2 and bishop on g5. Recorded reply: **15.Bxd8**.

15...Nxd2 The knight captures the queen on d2.

At the end, nominal material is White 22 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: knight on e4. Check for tactical protection.